WHAT IF DEMOCRACY FAILS TO DELIVER EQUALITY? STATE-INITIATED VIOLENCE IN DEMOCRATIC REGIMES

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INTRODUCTION

In an era of economic inequality and political polarization, the limits of democracy are increasingly under scrutiny.

This study seeks to answer how democracy and economic equality interact to influence state-initiated violence against civilians

This research contributes to understanding this intersection by focusing this particularly understudied form of conflict.

THEORITICAL FRAMEWORK

PART I

The Interplay between <u>democracy</u> and <u>economic equality</u>.

PART II

The Intersection of Economic equality, Democracy, and <u>Violence</u>

PART I

Central Tenent

Lipset's (1959):

- higher levels of income and economic development sustain democratic institutions

Acemoglu and Robinson (2005) and Boix (2003):

- democracy's nature is inherently redistributive

Challenge Conventions

Ceka and Magalhaes (2019):

- high inequality in liberal democracies undermine trust in democratic institutions.

Kotschy and Sunde (2019):

- economic downturns disproportionately harm democratic quality, particularly in highly unequal societies.

Key insight: While democracy can promote equality, its **redistributive capacity is conditional on institutional strength and economic stability**.

PART II

In civil War Violence

Hegre et al. (2001)

- Democratic Civil Peace
- Fully democratic regimes are less prone to civil wars than autocracies
- Semi-democracies have the highest prone to conflict

In Rebel Group Violence

Hultman (2012)

- **Democracies are more vulnerable to civilian-targeted violence** during internal conflicts--more in semi-democracies
- Structural accountability in democracies incentivize rebels to target civilians

Gap Identified: The intersection of **economic equality**, **regime type**, and **state-initiated violence** remains underexplored.

HYPOTHESES

H1

Higher levels of **liberal democracy correlate with greater economic equality**, which in turn **reduces levels of internal violence**.

H2

A **drop in economic equality** while maintaining liberal democracy **increases** the **propensity for conflict against civilians**.

H3

Negative economic shocks increase the probability of conflict in semi-democratic regimes but have a weaker effect in fully democratic states.

DATASETS

V-Dem (Varieties of Democracy)

ACLED (Armed Conflict Location & Event Data)

ACLED

- **ACLED provides data, collected from a variety of sources, on political violence and conflict events globally. Events are geolocated and coded with details about actors, types of violence, and fatalities.**
- Data Scope:
  - **Time Range: 2010– 2023.**
  - **Relevant Variables:**
    - **Event type: "Violence against civilians."**
    - **Actor type: "State Forces."**

V-DEM

- V-Dem provides indices measuring political systems, democracy levels, and various socioeconomic factors globally.
- Data Scope:
  - Time Range: 2000–2023.
  - Relevant Variables:
- Liberal Democracy Index (v2x_libdem): Measures the level of democracy in a country, ranging from 0 (least) to 1 (most).
- Freedom of Peaceful Assembly (v2caassemb): Captures civil liberties.
- Economic Equality Index (v2xeg_eqdr): Tracks equity in resource distribution, ranging from 0 (least) to 1 (most).
- GDP Per Capita (e_gdppc): Proxy for economic development

MERGING DATA

V-Dem (Varieties of Democracy)

ACLED (Armed Conflict Location & Event Data)

- Aligned the **temporal ranges**
  - of ACLED (2010–2023) and V-Dem (2000–2023) to **2010-2023**.
- Merged by **year and country**: Country-level data from V-Dem were merged with event-level data from ACLED by year and country.
- Country **Name Standardization**:
  - (e.g., "Ivory Coast" → "Côte d'Ivoire").

Methodology

Method 1: Panel regression

Method 2: Difference-in-Differences (DiD)

Method 3: Negative economic shock analysis

Method 1: Panel Regression

Violence = β1(Liberal Democracy) + β2(Economic Equality) + β3(Controls) + FE + ε.

- Dependent Variable:
  - Annual state initiated violence against civilians (ACLED).
- Independent Variables:
  - **Liberal Democracy Index (v2x_libdem), 0-1.**
  - **Economic Equality Index(v2xeg_eqdr), 0-1.**
- Control Variables:
  - **GDP per capita (e_gdppc).**
  - **Freedom of Peaceful Assembly (v2caassemb).**

Echoing H1: Higher levels of liberal democracy correlate with greater economic equality, which in turn reduces levels of internal violence.

Method 2: Difference-in-Differences (DiD)

- **Treatment** Group:
  - Countries experiencing a significant **drop in economic equality, defined as within the 10th percentile** of **year-over-year changes** in economic equality (v2xeg_eqdr).
- **Control** Group:
  - Countries with stable or increasing economic equality (economic equality changes **above the 10th percentile**).
- Stratification:
  - **Liberal-democracy levels (v2x_libdem > 0.5).**

Echoing H2: A drop in economic equality while maintaining liberal democracy increases the propensity for conflict against civilians.

Method 3: Negative Economic Shock Analysis

Probability of conflict: GDP drops >5% + regime types

GDP Shock:

- Threshold: GDP drop>5%, measured as year-over-year percentage change in GDP per capita.
- Democracy Level (v2x_libdem); 0-1:
  - **Autocracies: v2x_libdem < 0.3**
  - **Semi-Democracies: 0.3≤v2x_libdem<0.5**
  - **Liberal-Democracies: v2x_libdem≥0.5.**

Echoing H3: Negative economic shocks increase the probability of conflict in semi-democratic regimes but have a weaker effect in fully

Arguments	Hypotheses	Method
Democratic Stability and Equality	**H1**: Higher levels of **liberal democracy correlate with greater economic equality**, which in turn **reduces levels of internal violence**.	**Panel Regression**: Violence = β1(Liberal Democracy) + β2(Economic Equality) + β3(Controls) + FE + ε. - Controls: GDP per capita, political stability.
Economic Shocks and Inequality	**H2**: A **drop in economic equality** while maintaining liberal democracy **increases** the **propensity for conflict against civilians**.	**Difference-in-Differences (DiD)**: - Treatment Group: Countries with significant equality drops (bottom 10%). - Control Group: Stable equality.
Regime Resilience to Economic Shocks	**H3**: **Negative economic shocks** increase the probability of conflict in semi-democratic regimes but have a weaker effect in fully democratic states.	**Shock Analysis**: - Calculate the probability of conflict with threshold: GDP drop>5%. - Compare conflict trends by regime type.

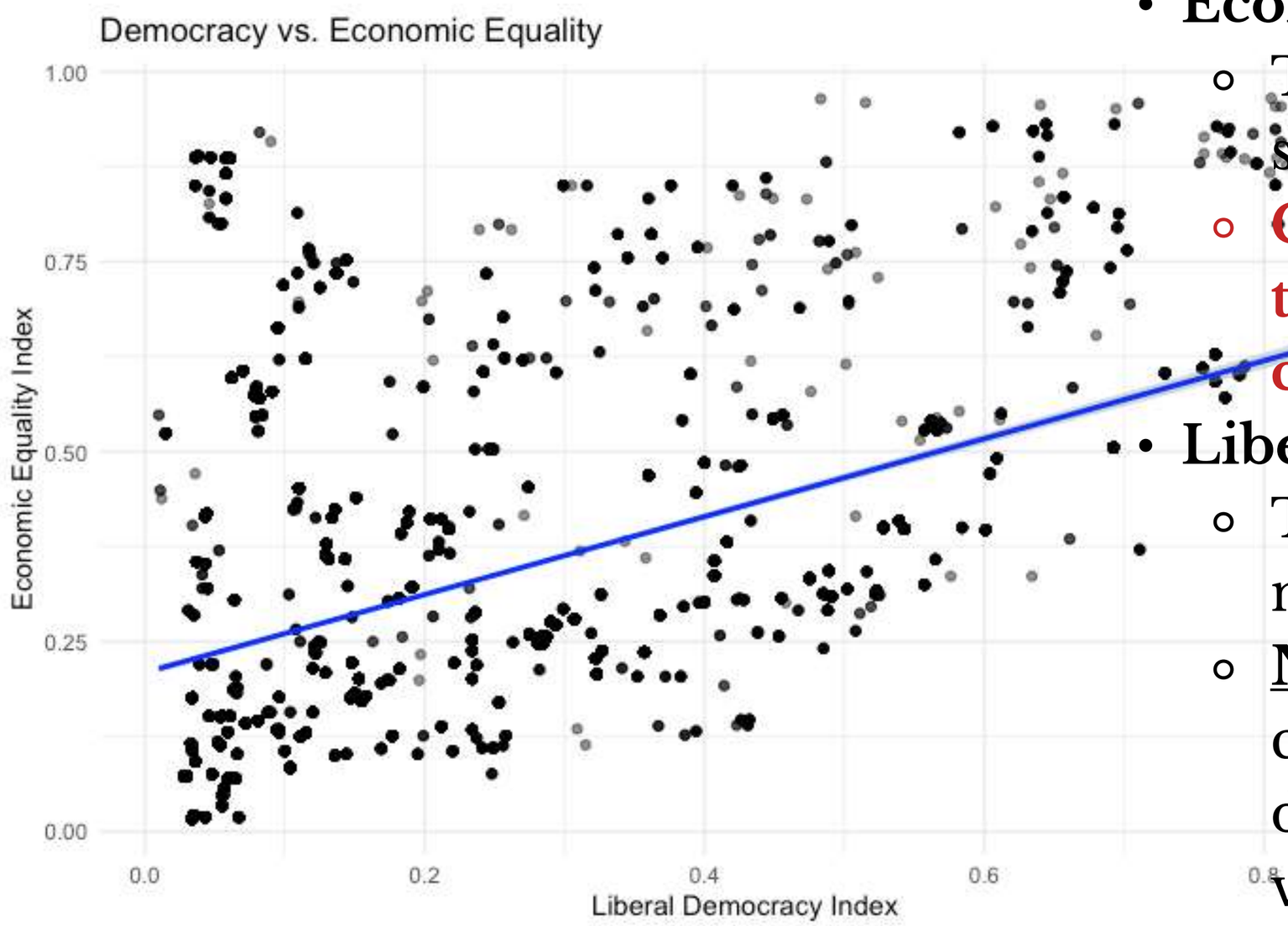
RESULT: PANEL REGRESSION

	Dependent variable:
	Violence Against Civilians (Event Count)
	(1)
Economic Equality Index (v2xeg_eqdr)	-0.600***
	(0.140)
Liberal Democracy Index (v2x_libdem)	0.100
	(0.160)
Constant	5.100***
	(0.300)
Observations	16,321
R2	0.050
Adjusted R2	0.045
Residual Std. Error	3.500 (df = 16,318)
F Statistic	23.000*** (df = 2; 16,318)

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

- **Economic Equality Index :**
  - The coefficient is -0.600, significant at the $p < 0.01$ level.
  - **Greater economic equality tends to reduce violence against civilians.**
- **Liberal Democracy Index :**
  - The coefficient is 0.100, but it is not statistically significant.
  - **No strong evidence** that changes in the level of democracy directly affect violence against civilians.

There is **positive association** in the two variables



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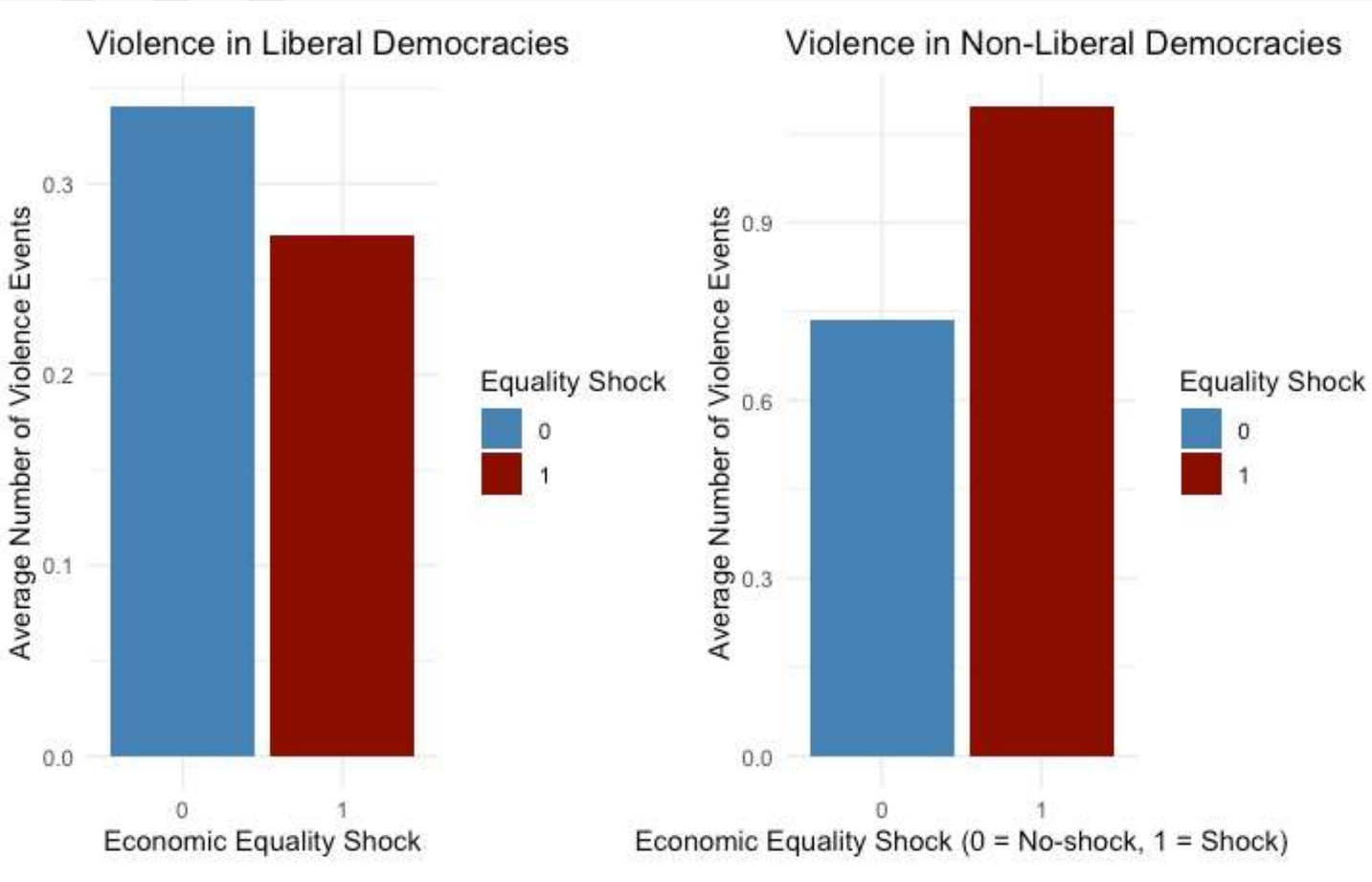


Violence in Liberal Democracies (Left Panel):

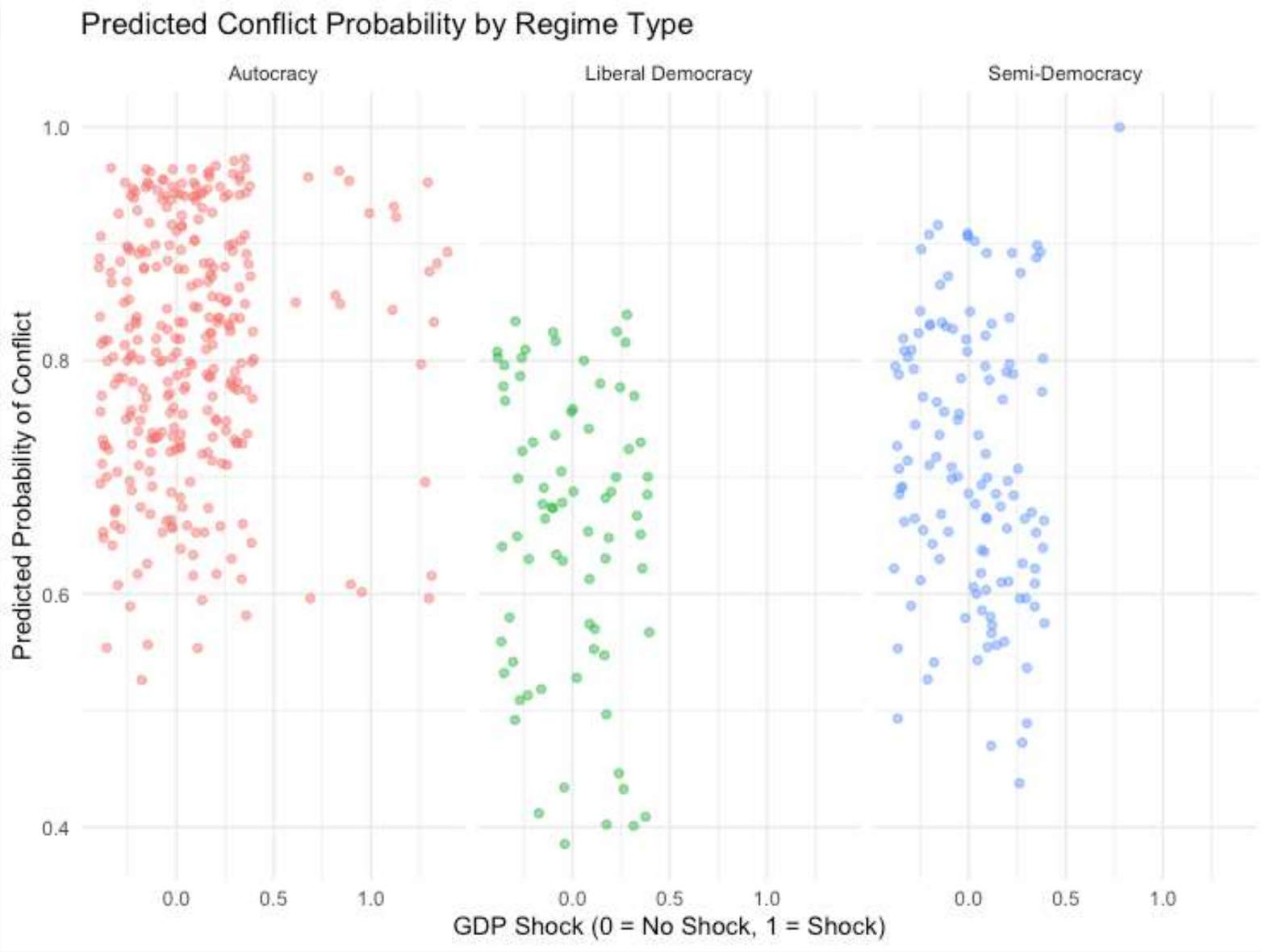
- Average level of violence is lower not considering shocks

Violence in Non-Liberal Democracies (Right Panel):

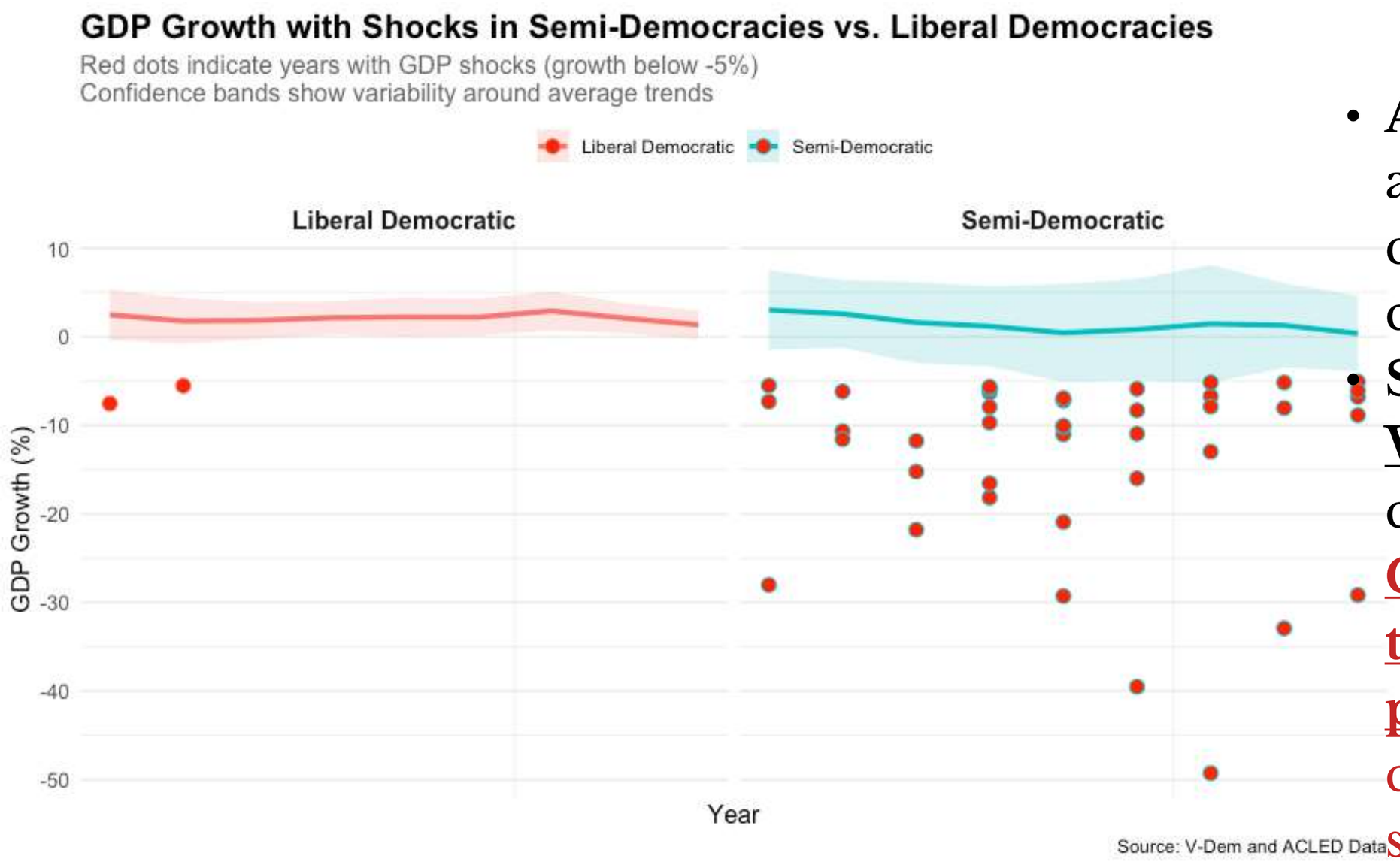
- Countries experiencing equality shocks exhibit significantly higher average violence levels.

Non-liberal democracies appear more vulnerable to economic shocks

RESULT: ECONOMIC SHOCK ANALYSIS



- **Autocracies:** Highest average predicted conflict probability--close to 1.
- **Semi-democracies:** **Widest range** of conflict probabilities; **GDP shocks increase the predicted probability of conflict** compared to no-shock scenarios



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DISCUSSION

Economic Equality Reduces Violence while the role of liberal democracy is less clear.

Non-liberal democracies are more susceptible to economic equality shocks and violent event.

Liberal-democracies have the lowest probability of conflict and GDP shock.

RESULT

That challenged expectations

1. **Liberal Democracy's Direct Role:**
   - **Liberal democracy's** protective effects on violence are **indirect** and mediated through economic equality or governance quality.
2. **Shocks and Conflict:**
   - For liberal democracies drop in economic equality **do not consistently predict violence**, it can lead to inverse correlation.

LIMITATIONS

⚙ DATASETS

Proxy Measures:

- Reliance on only on **one variable** (V-Dem v2xeg_eqdr) to account for economic equality can be affecting result

Temporal Scope:

- 2010-2023 may **not be long enough**

Bias Toward Sub-Saharan Africa:

- ACLED's event coverage is **disproportionately focused on Sub-Saharan Africa**. Findings may reflect regional patterns rather than global trends.

LIMITATIONS

METHDOLOGY

Defining Regime Types and Shocks:

- The classification of **full and semi-democracies** may not capture the complexity of regime types, also the threshold for **GDP shocks** may be too big/small.

Causation vs. Correlation:

- While the regression models control for confounding variables like GDP per capita or Freedom of Peaceful Assembly, they **cannot conclusively establish causation.**

THANK YOU